Section I

READING

Listen to the teacher read a diary account of a school boy and answer the questions.

Each day is a new beginning. It has so much to unfold and I had the best day at school today.

Cricket is something that I love. Today my teacher told us that we would be learning about a cricketer. I thought of Sachin, Virat Kohli and many other male players in the Indian cricket team but she introduced Mithali Dorai Raj, an Indian cricketer and the captain of the Indian women's cricket team in Tests and One Day Internationals [ODIs]. I never thought a woman could play cricket so well. It was why I have never let my little sister play cricket with me. I would tell her, "It is not for you; you had better play with girls." However, I was taken by surprise, when I learnt that Mithali started to play the game at the age of 10, and that she was selected for the Indian team at the age of 17.



Mithali Dorai Raj

Mithali lives in Hyderabad. I was interested to learn that her mother tongue is Tamil. I felt very proud that she has been widely **recognised** and **acknowledged**. She was the highest run scorer in Women's International Cricket and the only woman cricketer to surpass the 6,000-run mark in ODIs. Mithali is the first player to score seven **consecutive** 50s. In fact, she is nicknamed "Tendulkar of Indian women's cricket" as she is presently the all-time leading run scorer for India in all formats, including Tests, ODIs and T20s. I would love to quote what Mithali had to say about this compliment,

She said, **"On the one hand, being compared to Sachin is an absolute privilege. I do not think I have achieved even half of what he did for the country. On the other, being a woman cricketer, I want people to know me for my own identity. I would rather not be compared to a male cricketer."**

She indeed is an **inspiration** to all of us. She actually started playing cricket with her brother. When she was young, she used to go with her father to the grounds where he practised. She used to stand outside the ground and returned the ball when it came her way. Though it was a humble start, she managed to secure a name and a place for herself. Many of us think cricket is for men; however, she broke the traditional barriers and proved that women are on par with men in every field. The Government of India in recognition of her contribution to cricket conferred on her the **Padma Shri** Award.

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